PENNSYLVANIA

The Keystone State



Philadelphia has always been a city of strong opinions—about its sports teams, its neighborhoods, and above all, its food. It should surprise no one that a sandwich born on a South Philly street corner in the early 1930s became one of the most fiercely defended culinary traditions in American history.

Pat Olivieri was a hot dog vendor working near the Italian Market on South 9th Street, in a neighborhood that smelled of aged provolone, fresh bread, and the particular ambition of immigrant families who had come from southern Italy and made this stretch of Philadelphia their own. The Italian Market, established in the late 1800s, was the beating heart of South Philadelphia—a place where Sicilian, Neapolitan, and Calabrian vendors hawked produce, meat, and cheese from open stalls along the sidewalk, the way their families had done in the old country. It was working-class, loud, and alive.

The story goes that one afternoon, tired of his own hot dogs, Pat threw some thinly sliced beef onto his grill and stuffed it into an Italian roll. A cab driver passing by caught the smell, asked for one, and word traveled quickly the way it always does in a neighborhood where everyone knows everyone. Pat's corner became a destination. He eventually opened Pat's King of Steaks at 9th Street and Passyunk Avenue, a corner that still operates today and remains one of the most visited food landmarks in Pennsylvania.

The cheese came later—sometime in the 1940s, when Pat's nephew Joe Lorenzo is credited with adding provolone, and eventually Cheez Whiz entered the conversation, becoming for many the definitive and unapologetic choice. The sandwich had found its final form: thinly shaved ribeye, griddled with onions on a flat iron surface, piled into a hinged Amoroso roll—the long, slightly crisp Italian roll baked locally that cheesesteak purists insist cannot be authentically replicated anywhere outside the Philadelphia region. They are probably right.

By mid-century the cheesesteak had spread beyond South Philly into every corner of the city, from the rowhouse neighborhoods of Kensington and Fishtown to the lunch counters of Center City office workers. It crossed economic lines in a way few foods do—equally at home in a stadium, a corner shop, or on a paper plate balanced on the hood of a car at two in the morning. Pennsylvania had produced a sandwich that required no silverware, no ceremony, and no explanation.

What makes it worth making at home is exactly what made it worth eating on that South Philly corner nearly a century ago—the simplicity of good beef, good bread, and the confidence to keep it honest. When the ribeye hits a hot cast iron pan and the onions go soft and golden alongside it, the smell alone will tell you that you're doing something right. This is a sandwich that rewards boldness. Don't rush it, don't overthink it, and don't be shy with the cheese.

PHILLY CHEESESTEAK

Pat Olivieri's 1930s street-cart invention—shaved ribeye, molten cheese, soft-roll magic—is a love letter to Philadelphia.

Yield: 2 sandwiches

INGREDIENTS

- 8–9 oz. well-marbled boneless ribeye, fat cap left on
- ½ tsp salt
- ¼ tsp freshly ground black pepper
- ½ tsp Worcestershire sauce
- 1 Tbsp unsalted butter, softened
- 1 small garlic clove, pressed
- 2 long Amoroso-style hoagie rolls (soft, chewy, crusty—not a stiff baguette)
- 1 Tbsp neutral oil (or a knob of butter), for the griddle
- ½ large sweet onion, thinly sliced
- 2 slices white American cheese
- 1 slice mild provolone (not aged)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Freeze, then shave the ribeye*: Place the ribeye in the freezer for 30–45 minutes, until firm but not frozen solid. Using your sharpest knife, slice it as thinly as humanly possible—paper-thin against the grain. Thin is everything: the meat should almost dissolve, not eat like a steak sandwich. Once sliced, roughly chop the pile a few times so it's ready to break apart on the griddle. Toss with the salt, pepper, and Worcestershire.
2. *Make the garlic butter and prep the rolls*: Stir the softened butter together with the pressed garlic. Slice the hoagie rolls about three-quarters through lengthwise, leaving it hinged. Spread the cut sides with the garlic butter and set aside.
3. *Caramelize the onion*: Heat a large flat skillet, griddle, or cast iron over medium heat. Add a touch of oil and the sliced onion with a pinch of salt. Cook, stirring occasionally, until soft and golden, 6–8 minutes. Push the onion off to one side of the cooking surface, or scrape it into a bowl and briefly set aside.
4. *Toast the rolls*: Toasting the rolls in garlic butter is what makes it taste like garlic bread and gives it the backbone to hold the juicy filling without going soggy. Lay the buttered hoagie cut-side down on a hot dry section of the griddle and toast until golden and crisp, 1–2 minutes. Set aside, cut-side up.
5. *Griddle and chop the beef*: Raise the heat to medium-high and add the oil or butter. Spread the shaved ribeye in a thin, even layer—don't crowd it, or it will steam and turn gray instead of browning. Let it sear undisturbed for about a minute to grab color, then use two spatulas (or a stiff bench scraper) to chop and fold the meat repeatedly as it cooks. It's done in just 2–3 minutes, as soon as no raw pink remains. Overcooking is the enemy of a tender cheesesteak.
6. *Marry the onions and melt the cheese*: Fold the caramelized onion back into the chopped beef and gather everything into a roll-length pile on the griddle. Lay the American and provolone slices directly over the hot meat. To melt them fast, either cover with a lid or metal bowl for 30–60 seconds, or splash a teaspoon of water beside the pile and cover to steam the cheese into a glossy, gooey blanket. The American-plus-provolone combination gives you creaminess and sharpness at once—better than either cheese alone.

7. *Assemble the Philly way*: Nestle the open toasted roll upside down directly over the cheese-covered pile. Slide a spatula under the meat and, in one confident motion, flip the whole thing—meat, cheese, and roll—right-side up so the filling drops cleanly into the bread. Press gently.
8. *Serve immediately*: Cut in half if you like and eat it hot, right away, while the cheese is molten and the roll is crisp—ideally with a side of chips or fries and a few pickled hot peppers.

